

"I don't resent the star status of cricketers, I feel the media could be more supportive of other sports."

FEATHER TOUCH

Oriental and Occidental, he was Asian by birth but at home in Europe and was the only Indian in the world top ten for a decade

Prakash Padukone

Badminton player 1955

■ By Dev S. Sukumar

In July 2005, a packed hall of Indonesians gave a thundering ovation to an Indian badminton player in Jakarta more than a decade after he had last played there. What was it, I wondered, about Prakash Padukone that endeared him to a people whose language he couldn't even speak? The Indonesians, unbeatable in the '60s and '70s, were toppled by the Chinese who came out of international isolation in May 1981. They stunned everybody with their speed and power, and Padukone first showed how they could be countered. Using control and precision, he would slow the game to his pace and

his deception would keep them off-balance. People still recall the 15-0 thrashing of Han Jian in the 1981 World Cup final at Kuala Lumpur. "I didn't know what happened," said Han Jian recently.

Padukone was there at the right place at the right time. He was there when the era of prize money tournaments began (he won the first Open tournament—the London Masters in 1979) and he was there when television arrived. Among the uncommunicative badminton community, only he and Denmark's Morten Frost could articulate the players' perspective to the English media. He was Oriental and Occidental—Asian by upbringing, but

at home in Europe. His best friend was Frost, and the two trained and hung out together.

What is it about his game that no Indian has been able to replicate with equal success thus far? Only Pullela Gopichand has cracked the world's top ten, and that too for two years, but Padukone was there for a decade. Never in his prime did he lose to a no-namer and never did he let the country down in team matches.

There have been great singles players in India but Padukone had the biggest impact on the world's perception of Indian badminton.

The author has written Touch Play, the biography of Prakash Padukone

GIREESH GV



Q: Which was his first major international title?

A: Gold at the Commonwealth Games

Q: Who was the Danish player with whom he used to train?

A: Morten Frost Hansen

Q: When did Padukone win the Grand Slam?

A: In 1980

